In none of these cases could the secret police defeat the regular army in traditional warfare, of course; what made the secret police powerful was its command of information. It had the information necessary to pre-empt a military coup and to arrest the commanders of tank brigades or fighter squadrons before they knew what hit them. During the Stalinist Great Terror of the late 1930s, out of 144,000 Red Army officers about 10 percent were shot or imprisoned by the NKVD. This included 154 of 186 divisional commanders (83 per cent), eight of nine admirals (89 per cent), thirteen of fifteen full generals (87 per cent) and three of five marshals (60 per cent).[77]

The party leadership fared just as badly. Of the revered Old Bolsheviks, people who joined the party before the 1917 revolution, about a third didn't survive the Great Terror.[78] Of the thirty-three men who served on the Politburo between 1919 and 1938, fourteen were shot (42 per cent). Of the 139 members and candidate members of the party's Central Committee in 1934, 98 (70 per cent) were shot. Only 2 per cent of the delegates who took part in the Seventeenth Party Congress in 1934 evaded execution, imprisonment, expulsion, or demotion and attended the Eighteenth Party Congress in 1939.[79]

The secret police – which did all the purging and killing – was itself divided into several competing branches that closely watched and purged one another. Genrikh Yagoda, the NKVD head who orchestrated the beginning of the Great Terror and supervised the killing of hundreds of thousands of victims, was executed in 1938 and replaced by Nikolai Yezhov. Yezhov lasted for two years, killing and imprisoning millions of people before being executed in 1940.

Perhaps most telling is the fate of the thirty-nine people who in 1935 held the rank of general in the NKVD (called commissars of state security in Soviet nomenclature). Thirty-five of them (90 per cent) were arrested and shot by 1941, one was assassinated, and one – the head of the NKVD's Far East regional office – saved himself by defecting to Japan, but was killed by the Japanese in 1945. Of the original cohort of thirty-nine NKVD generals, only two men were left standing by the end of the Second World War. The remorseless logic of totalitarianism eventually caught up with them too. During the power struggles that followed Stalin's death in 1953, one of them was shot, while the other was consigned to a psychiatric hospital, where he died in 1960.[80] Serving as an NKVD general in Stalin's day was